



TUNIS TUNISIA

A Tricky Treat in Tunis

Africa meets Europe in Tunisia's buzzing capital city, Tunis. Within the ancient medina, shoppers wander the labyrinthine paths of the souks, while in the modern city outside, businessmen sip coffee and read European newspapers. Come lunchtime, though, they're all likely to be tucking into the same dish: *brik à l'oeuf*, Tunisia's most delicious – and challenging – treat.



Tunis sits along Tunisia's northern coast, tucked into the innermost corner of the Gulf of Tunis. Its modern outlook and cosmopolitan air make it one of the most accessible North African destinations for visitors. But it exudes plenty of exotic atmosphere too, in the exquisitely tiled mosques and minarets towering above the rooftops, the arched courtyards and decorative doorways, the echoing cry of the muezzin calling the faithful to prayer, and the pungent smells of spice and perfume.

The city's impressive Roman history is another of its highlights, from the exquisite mosaics in the Bardo Museum to the outstanding ruins at Dougga, a day-trip away. The suburbs contain the remnants of an even more ancient empire, Carthage. From here the seafaring Phoenicians dominated the Mediterranean in the 6th century BC. Since then Arab, Ottoman, and French settlers have all influenced Tunisia's culture and cuisine.

Brik à l'oeuf is one such dish that Tunisians have made their own. This delicious triangular parcel of thin pastry, which may be filled with seafood, minced lamb, beef, or vegetables and herbs, but always includes an egg yolk, is fried in oil and eaten with the fingers.

It has its roots in the deep-fried *börek* of Turkish cuisine and in fact the unusual name, *brik*, is simply the local variation on the original Turkish word.

But with *brik à l'oeuf*, the Tunisians have made this humble snack food into a work of art. The most impressive briks are more than a hand-span wide, their paper-thin shells shaped like a fan and held daintily upright in a sliced lemon. The brik is often enlivened by fiery harissa, a spicy red mix of hot chili peppers and olive oil, mashed together into a paste. If you don't like hot sauces, don't even look at harissa – it might make your eyes water. However, it's so popular with the locals that many brik recipes include harissa in the filling, so if you can't stomach the heat, make sure to ask for one without. In Tunisia, harissa is almost always put on the table at the start of a meal, perhaps with some olives and bread as an *hors d'oeuvre*. Each chef or household will have their own recipe, and fancier versions might include cumin, coriander, and other herbs and spices.

The challenge in eating a *brik à l'oeuf* – especially the large, elaborate ones – is to control the runny egg yolk that explodes with the first bite. Once you can eat one without it running down your chin, then you've mastered the trick of the most Tunisian brik.

A Day in Tunis

The medina, Tunis's walled old town, is a UNESCO World Heritage site harboring a feast of Islamic architecture. From here, a short (and inexpensive) taxi ride will take you to sights in the surrounding new town and farther out along the coast.

MORNING Wander through the streets of the **medina** and soak up the atmosphere, admiring the beautifully carved and tiled decoration on the mosques and minarets. Dodge the carpet-sellers and go shopping in the mesmerizing bazaars of the souks.

AFTERNOON Visit the **Bardo Museum** to see the finest collection of Roman mosaics in the world. Then take a taxi to **Carthage** to see the **Antonine Baths**, the best of the scattered ruins of the once-great Phoenician civilization.

EVENING With its whitewashed, blue-shuttered houses and elaborate painted doors, the hilltop town of **Sidi Bou Saïd** is a favorite stop for visitors, just 12 miles (20 km) from Tunis. Its café terraces are grand spots from which to sip a mint tea and watch the sun set over the sea.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Buses and **taxis** link Tunis-Carthage **international airport** with the downtown. Explore central Tunis on **foot**, or take **taxis** farther afield.

WHERE TO STAY

Hotel Majestic (inexpensive) is located on the edge of the medina. +216 71 332 666

Hotel Carlton (moderate) is a central, three-star Art Deco hotel. www.hotelcarlton.tunis.com

The **Oriental Palace** (expensive) is luxurious and sumptuously decorated. +216 71 348 846

TOURIST INFORMATION

Tunisia National Office of Tourism, 1 Avenue Mohamed V, Tunis; +216 71 341 077

